

These interested, knowledgeable, and committed shareholders permit the Mulliez businesses to take a more long-term outlook. They are not particularly concerned with quarterly results or with dividend payouts. What concerns them is the growth and health of the extended business empire of which they are all part.

This is just a guess, but we think families such as the Mulliezes are likely to be much more important in the future than they were in the recent past. Family money, in particular, is likely to be much more appreciated.

THE FAMILY VS. THE STATE

People are social animals. They need organizations, institutions, and collective arrangements that suit them. Family organizations come naturally. The family, extended to uncles, aunts, cousins, and so forth, has been the most important grouping for most of our time as humans. It used to be the family that provided most of our wants and needs—from shelter to food, clothing, entertainment, companionship—you name it. The “means of production” were controlled by the family. Production took place within the family. Only mating was, and still is, usually done outside of the family.

The Old Testament is largely a story of families. And the development of the Roman Empire, too, is a history of a small group of families on the banks of the Tiber that managed to gain control over much of the known world.

In Ireland, where we have our family office headquarters, family-based political and economic power lasted up until the time it was crushed by Oliver Cromwell’s armies in the seventeenth century. Even today, the Irish parliament is known as the Fine Gael, or the “Gaelic families.”

Families receded in importance with the rise of the social welfare nation-state. The promise of modern government was that it would take care of its people. And the illusion was that it didn’t matter what kind of family you came from, that you would be equal to every other citizen. You would have equal access to public transportation, public education, job opportunities, and, ultimately—a good life.